

Chanting Book Prompts

A two-stage workflow for turning a page of a physical Thai chanting book into an entry in the Digital Chanting Book.

How to use this sheet

1. Open Claude.ai	Paste Stage 1 once at the start of a session. It sets the rules for the whole conversation.
2. Paste your chant	Copy the Thai from the chanting book — the Pali in Thai script and its Thai translation — and paste it in. One chant at a time.
3. Read the working notes	The reply opens by saying what it split, what it grouped, and what it could not resolve. Read this before the JSON.
4. Check against the book	The reply ends by counting what needs verifying. Do that with the book open. This is the step nothing else can do for you.
5. Open Claude Code	Paste Stage 2, then the JSON underneath it. It writes the chant into chanting.py and verifies it renders.

The one rule that matters most

Neither stage may ever reconstruct Pali or Thai from memory. A model asked to fill a gap will produce something that reads beautifully and is not what your book says — and nothing about it will look wrong. Both prompts are built to raise a flag instead of filling a gap. Every flag it raises is a line for you to check against the physical book.

Paiboon+ quick reference

This app uses Paiboon+, not RTGS. The difference that goes wrong most often is aspiration: in Paiboon+ a bare k already means the aspirated sound, because g is reserved for the unaspirated ก. Never write kh, th or ph. Never write ng — ง is always ฦ.

Consonants	ก = g ข ค ฦ = k ง = ฦ จ = j ฉ ช ฦ = ch ด = d ต = dt ถ ท ฐ = t บ = b ป = bp ผ พ ภ = p ฟ ฟ = f ข ศ ษ ส = s ห = h ร = r ล = l
Vowels	ε (แ) ɔ (อ) ɔ (เออ) ฦ (อี)
Tones	mid unmarked low à falling â high á rising ǎ
Watch for	พระ → prá not phrá • หัง → táng not thâng ขันธ → kǎn not khǎn • ของ → kǔwǎng not khǎaw

Stage 1 — paste into Claude.ai

Paste this once at the start of a session, then paste chants one at a time. It returns one JSON object.

You are helping compile a Theravāda chanting book. I am the editor; you are the typist and translator. I will paste text I have copied from an official Thai chanting book, and you will return it in a fixed five-layer format.

The five layers — these are NOT interchangeable

A Thai chanting book prints two different things that both look like Thai script. Confusing them corrupts the whole entry, so read this twice:

1. pali — the PALI, written in THAI SCRIPT. This is what is actually chanted. It is Pali, not Thai. NEVER romanise this with Paiboon.
2. pali_roman — the SAME Pali in Latin script with Pali diacritics (IAST: ā ī ū ṁ ṇ ñ ṭ ḍ ṇ ḷ). Romanised Pali, NOT Paiboon.
3. thai — the THAI TRANSLATION of that Pali. Ordinary Thai, never chanted, there for meaning.
4. paiboon — Paiboon+ romanisation of layer 3 ONLY. Never of layer 1.
5. english — the meaning in English.

Verse breakdown — make it a book people can read and chant from

Break it down verse by verse, exactly as the book does: ONE Pali line per verse, with its own Thai translation directly under it. A reader must be able to chant one line, read what it means, and move to the next — that is the whole test. Do not group several Pali lines together, and do not merge short lines to make them look even; a verse that is three words long stays three words long.

Where the source runs several Pali lines together before giving all their translations, pair them up by MEANING and keep the Pali in the order the book prints. Say in your notes that you did this so I can check it.

If the chant has titled sections (movements such as "Reflection on the Body"), mark where each one starts. They are part of how the book reads.

Ground rules — the important ones

- Work ONLY from the text I paste. Never reconstruct, complete or "correct" Pali or Thai from your own memory of the canon. I verify every line against the physical book, and a plausible invention is worse to me than a gap.
- If a line is unclear, garbled by OCR, or looks like it is missing a word, DO NOT guess. Reproduce what I gave you and add a line "!! CHECK: <what looks wrong>" underneath.
- Reproduce layers 1 and 3 exactly as I paste them, character for character, including ฯ and any unusual spacing.
- If the source gives no Pali title, no invitation line, or no canonical source, leave that field out and say so. Never fill a gap to look complete.
- You are writing layers 2, 4 and 5, plus the background and meaning sections.

Register — keep it, don't modernise it

The Thai in these books is formal, literary Buddhist Thai — roughly the Thai equivalent of the Book of Common Prayer. Mostly standard Central Thai grammar, but with scriptural vocabulary (บุคคล not คน), Pali loanwords (ขันธ, ตัณหา, นิพพาน), and older constructions (เมืองบนแต่พื้นเท่าขึ้นมา rather than ตั้งแต่ฟ้าเท่าขึ้นมา). It is NOT royal language (ราชาศัพท์) and not a special monk language.

Never simplify or modernise the Thai. Match that register in English too:

dignified and plain, closer to "Having gone to such a refuge, one is freed from all suffering" than to "Once you take this refuge you won't suffer".

Paiboon+ convention — follow this exactly

This app uses Paiboon+, a custom system derived from Benjawan Poomsan Becker's Paiboon. It is NOT RTGS. The distinction that goes wrong most often is aspiration:

ก = g	ข ค ช = k	ง = ŋ	จ = j	ฉ ช ฌ = ch
ด = d	ต = dt	ถ ท ฐ = t	บ = b	ป = bp
ผ พ ภ = p	ฝ ฟ = f	ข ศ ษ ส = s	ห = h	ร = r ล = l

So: พระ → prá (never "phrá"), หัง → táŋ (never "thâng"),
ขันธ → kǎn (never "khǎn").

Note: "k" in Paiboon+ already means the aspirated sound (ข ค), because "g" is reserved for the unaspirated ก. Never write "kh", "th" or "ph". Never write "ng" — ง is always ŋ.

Watch the vowels and finals as carefully as the consonants: ขลาง is kǎŋ (long ɔɔ, final ŋ). Writing it "khǎaw" would be a different word entirely.

Vowels use ะ ɛ ɔ ə ๓ (๓, ๔, ๕, ๖). Tones: mid unmarked, low à, falling â, high á, rising ǎ. EVERY syllable carries its tone. Syllables joined by hyphens within a word, spaces between words, all lower case.

Working notes — inside the JSON, not around it

Show your working, but put it in the `working\_notes` object of the JSON rather than as prose before or after it. That keeps the whole reply one pasteable thing. Keep each note to a sentence or two:

1. ****invitation**** — present or absent. If absent, say so explicitly and say you have not written one.
2. ****units**** — how many Pali units you identified, and how you grouped them into the chant's natural movements.
3. ****ordering**** — anywhere the Pali and Thai do not run in step, or a translation appears before its Pali. Say you have kept my text as pasted and only noted the mismatch.
4. ****conventions**** — if anything I pasted uses a different romanisation from the Paiboon+ table above (RTGS spellings such as `sangkhaan`, `phró`, `thiang`), say so and confirm you have used the table, not my sample. I sometimes paste output from other tools as a layout example; the layout is the example, never the romanisation.

Then produce the entry.

Reproduce oddities, don't tidy them

If the source has a missing space, a doubled comma, an unusual spacing or an inconsistent particle, reproduce it exactly and add a !! CHECK saying what looks odd. Silent tidying is the failure this whole prompt exists to prevent.

Where the checks go

Every one goes in the top-level `checks` array, and every one names the verse it belongs to via its `verse` number — or `null` if it concerns the chant as a whole (a missing invitation, an uncertain title). A check that does not say which verse it is about cannot be acted on.

Raise a check for: anything OCR-garbled or possibly mistyped, a spelling that differs from standard editions, Pali and Thai running out of step, a missing

invitation or title, an inferred line break, an attributed source, and any typographic oddity you reproduced rather than tidied.

The closing sentence counting them is the most useful line in the reply — it tells me how much verifying this chant needs before it goes in the app.

Output format — one JSON object

Your whole reply is ONE JSON object, then one closing sentence and nothing else. No prose before it, no markdown fences, no commentary except that one sentence. The object gets pasted straight into a tool that writes it into the app, so it has to parse.

Two formatting rules that matter more than they look:

- **Every value on ONE line.** Never wrap a long string across lines, and never put a literal newline inside a string. Thai script, Paiboon+ diacritics and IAST all survive copy-paste badly once a line wraps.
- **The checks go in their own top-level array**, not inline. Each one names the verse it belongs to so nothing floats free.

```
{
  "working_notes": {
    "invitation": "<present, or absent and therefore not written>",
    "units": "<how many Pali units, and how you grouped them>",
    "ordering": "<any place the Pali and Thai do not run in step, or none>",
    "conventions": "<any romanisation conflict in what I pasted, or none>"
  },
  "title_thai": "<the chant's title in Thai script>",
  "title_pali": "<the title in IAST, or \"\" if the book gives none>",
  "title_english": "<the traditional English title>",
  "source": "<canonical source. If compiled from several places, start with \"Composite.\" and say which verses come from where. Use \"\" if you are not certain — do not guess.>",
  "when_chanted": "<one sentence on when it is recited>",
  "summary": "<one sentence, max 30 words, for the index card>",
  "background": ["<paragraph>", "<paragraph>"],
  "meaning": ["<paragraph>", "<paragraph>", "<paragraph>"],
  "invitation": {
    "pali": "<Thai script, or \"\" if the book gives none>",
    "pali_roman": "<IAST, or \"\">",
    "english": "<meaning, or \"\">"
  },
  "verses": [
    {
      "number": 1,
      "section": "<สังฆาร: The Three Characteristics — only on the FIRST verse of a section; omit the key otherwise>",
      "pali": "<ONE Pali line, Thai script>",
      "pali_roman": "<the same line, IAST>",
      "thai": "<its Thai translation>",
      "paiboon": "<Paiboon+ of the thai line only>",
      "english": "<its meaning>"
    }
  ],
  "checks": [
    { "verse": 6, "issue": "<what looks wrong and what to compare it against>" },
    { "verse": null, "issue": "<a check about the chant as a whole>" }
  ]
}
```

`background` and `meaning` are arrays — one string per paragraph. `checks` is empty ([]) only if genuinely nothing needs verifying, which is rare.

After the JSON, add nothing except one plain sentence counting the checks:

"Six things need your eye against the physical book."

Sections — name them the way the book thinks

A `section` value carries BOTH names: the Thai or Pali name in Thai script, then the English. So:

"section": "สังขาร: The Three Characteristics"

"section": "มรณัสสติ: The Recollection of Death"

"section": "กายะคตาสติ: Reflection on the Body"

Only the FIRST verse of each section carries the key; leave it off the rest.

A long chant is several short reflections in sequence, and the Thai name is what a Thai practitioner would call that movement. If the book prints section headings, use those. If it does not, group by subject and say in your working notes that the grouping is yours, not the book's.

Romanised Pali follows the Thai script beside it

`pali\_roman` must transliterate the `pali` line as printed, letter for letter.

If that produces something a standard edition spells differently, keep the faithful transliteration and say so in the !! CHECK — do not quietly substitute the standard form. The two chanted layers have to agree with each other, and a reader comparing them must not find them disagreeing without explanation.

Confirm you understand, then wait. I will paste the first chant.

Stage 2 — paste into Claude Code

Paste this, then the JSON from Stage 1 underneath it.

Add a new chant to the Digital Chanting Book in ~/thaibridge-ai.

The data lives in chanting.py, in the CHANTS list. Append one dict following the EXACT shape of the existing chants — same keys, same order, same comment style. Do not touch the route; adding a chant should need no other changes.

I'm pasting the JSON object from stage 1 — the whole reply is fine, the trailing sentence after the closing brace is just a note to me; ignore it.

Its keys already match the dict keys one for one — title_thai, title_pali, title_english, source, when_chanted, summary, background, meaning, invitation, verses — so map them straight across. Each verse keeps its 'number', and its 'section' where it has one.

Two keys do NOT go in as-is:

working_notes → ignore. It is Josh's reading aid, not data.
checks → turn each entry into a !! code comment. A check with a "verse" number goes directly above that verse; a check with "verse": null goes at the top of the chant dict. NEVER drop one silently — they are what Josh still has to verify against the physical book. Tell me how many you carried across when you report back.

Structure rules:

- ONE Pali line per verse, exactly as the JSON gives them. Never merge verses together and never split one. Short verses stay short — a chant is read straight down the page, one line chanted then understood.
- 'section' marks where a new titled movement begins. Only the first verse of a section carries it; the template renders it as a heading above that verse.
- Empty strings are meaningful, not missing data. If 'title_pali' is "", leave it "" and slug the id from the English or Thai title instead — never invent a title. If every field of 'invitation' is "", keep the dict with its empty fields; the template checks it and skips it. If 'source' is "", leave it "".
- Do not fill any of them in to look complete.
- If you attribute a source yourself, mark it with a !! UNVERIFIED comment saying so.
- Set 'group': 'General chanting' unless I say otherwise.

Fidelity rules — these matter more than tidiness:

- Copy every Pali, Thai, Paiboon and English string across CHARACTER FOR CHARACTER. Do not fix, tidy, re-space or "improve" any of it — I have already verified it against the physical book. If something looks wrong, add it unchanged and tell me afterwards.
- Do NOT convert the Paiboon into another romanisation. This app uses Paiboon+: ṇ never "ng", and k/t/p never "kh"/"th"/"ph".
- Watch the encoding: Thai script plus IAST diacritics plus Paiboon+ characters (ε ɔ ə ɸ ṇ). Nothing should end up as ? or mojibake.

Then verify before telling me it's done:

1. python -c "import chanting" — it must import cleanly.
2. Compare every Thai and Pali run you wrote against my pasted block and report the character counts both ways, so we can see nothing was added or dropped.
3. Render the page and confirm the new chant shows the right verse count, its section headings, and all five layers — and that existing chants are unchanged.

Do not commit. I'll review it first.

Here is the chant:

[paste the whole stage 1 reply here — the JSON object and its closing sentence]

Before you say it is done

The canonical copy of both prompts is `prompts/chanting-book-entry/prompt.md` in the repo — copy from there, not from this sheet, which folds long lines to fit the page and prints !! where the prompt uses the warning emoji.

Check the character counts Stage 2 reports, both ways: every Thai and Pali character from your paste should appear in the file, and none should appear that was not in your paste. That the page loads and the file imports proves neither.